Document Collection Guide

What to collect, how to photograph it, and what each document class means

Capstone Project — Inventory Management System · For team members collecting the corpus

We are building a system that reads a photograph of a paper supplier document and turns it into structured data automatically. To test whether it works, we need a set of real documents from real shops — that set is the **corpus**, and collecting it is the job described here.

The single most important rule

Photograph documents **with a phone camera, in the shop, under whatever lighting is there**. Do not scan them. Do not use a scanner app that flattens, crops, or auto-corrects the image. Our system will receive phone photos in real use, so our test data has to be phone photos too. A folder of clean scans cannot tell us whether the system actually works.

The four document classes

Every document we collect belongs to exactly one of four classes. Telling these apart automatically is the **main goal of our project**, which is why we need real examples of all four. The distinction matters because the same column of numbers means different things: a quantity on a delivery note is stock that *arrived*, while the same quantity on a purchase order is stock merely *ordered*.

1. Purchase Order

Goods ordered from a supplier — not yet received

What it looks like

- Line-item table listing products
- Both quantity and unit price columns
- Grand total block at the bottom
- Supplier letterhead at the top

Words printed on it

- "Purchase Order" or "P.O. No."
- "Order Date"
- "Ship To" / "Bill To"

Why we need it	It records what a shop ordered. Stock is expected but has not arrived yet.
Watch out for	Usually printed on a full A4 page. These are the easiest to read, so they are our baseline — if the system fails here, it fails everywhere.
Target	Mostly printed, a few handwritten

2. Delivery Note

Goods physically received — stock actually went up

What it looks like

- Line-item table listing products
- Quantity column present
- Prices often missing entirely
- Signature or receipt block

Words printed on it

- "Delivery Note" or "Challan"
- "Received By"
- "Dispatch" / "Delivered"

Why we need it	It proves goods arrived. The quantities on it are the authoritative record of a stock increase.
Watch out for	In Bangladesh these are very often called **Challan** and are frequently handwritten. This is the hardest class to find, so it is worth asking shops for specifically, by name.
Target	Mostly handwritten — the hardest class

3. Customer Copy

A duplicate record — must not be counted twice

What it looks like

- Looks almost identical to an invoice
- Carries an explicit copy marking
- Often duplicates a document already captured

Words printed on it

- "Customer Copy" or "Duplicate"
- "Office Copy"
- "Not for Payment"

Why we need it	It restates a transaction that may already be recorded. If the system mistakes it for a fresh invoice, stock gets double-counted.
Watch out for	The copy marking can be small, faint, or a rubber stamp in a corner. Make sure it is **visible and in focus** in your photo — that marking is the entire point of this class.
Target	Mostly printed, some thermal

4. Receipt / Cash Memo

A completed, paid purchase

What it looks like

- Narrow, single-column strip
- Thermal printing (fades, shiny paper)
- Item lines squeezed together
- Total plus payment block

Words printed on it

- "Receipt" or "Cash Memo"
- "Paid" / "Change"
- "Thank You"

Why we need it	It records a completed purchase that has been paid for.
Watch out for	Thermal paper **fades over time** and reflects light badly. This is the hardest class for the software to read, which makes it valuable — but photograph it carefully and avoid glare.
Target	Mostly thermal, some printed

How many of each

The numbers below are what we are aiming for. The mix of printed, thermal, and handwritten should reflect **what shops naturally have** — please do not hunt for handwritten documents just to fill a column, because that would make our results misleading.

Document class	Printed	Thermal	Handwritten	Minimum
Purchase order	majority	—	some	**30**
Delivery note / Challan	some	some	majority	**30**
Customer copy	majority	some	some	**30**
Receipt / Cash memo	some	majority	some	**30**

120 documents in total. If 30 per class proves unrealistic, tell the team early — a smaller honest set is far better than a padded one, and we can adjust the target. Do not invent or duplicate documents to reach a number.

How to photograph

- **Use a phone camera.** No scanners, no scanner apps, no photocopies, no photos of a screen.
- **One document per photo**, with the whole page inside the frame including all four edges.
- **Keep it in focus.** Blurry is unusable. Check the photo before moving on.
- **Avoid glare**, especially on shiny thermal receipts. Shift your angle rather than using flash.
- **Natural, in-shop lighting is correct** — even if it looks dim. Do not stage a clean, bright setup.
- **Do not crop, rotate, filter, or enhance** afterwards. Send the original file.
- **Flattened, not folded.** Smooth out creases where the shop allows it.

Permission before photography — not optional

These documents contain prices, supplier names, and trading relationships, which are commercially sensitive. Before photographing anything, tell the shop: what our project is; that the documents are for a university capstone project only; that identifying details will be removed from anything we publish; and that they may ask us to remove their documents later. **If they say no, thank them and move on.** Never photograph documents without the owner knowing.

What to record for every document

A photograph on its own is not usable data. Each one needs these six fields recorded in the shared sheet, or we cannot use it.

Field	What to write
File name	A unique ID, e.g. `PO_007.jpg`. Rename the photo to match.
Document class	Purchase order / Delivery note / Customer copy / Receipt — exactly one
Production method	Printed / Thermal / Handwritten
Shop	Which business it came from (so we can honour a withdrawal request)
Date collected	The day you photographed it
Collected by	Your name

A note on language

Our project is scoped to **English-language documents**. In practice most printed supplier invoices, purchase orders, and POS receipts in Bangladesh are in English or mixed script, and numerals are almost always English — so this is less limiting than it sounds. Handwritten challans are the most likely to be in Bangla.

If you find a document that is mostly Bangla, collect it anyway and note the language in the sheet. We would rather know how common that is than assume. It is a genuine finding either way, and it may change how we scope the project.

> **Before you go out — a ten-document test run**
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> Rather than committing to 120 documents up front, visit **two or three shops and collect about ten**. That tells us quickly what is actually out there: whether challans are findable, how much is in English, and whether shops are willing at all. Report back before the full push. An afternoon spent here can save weeks of chasing documents that do not exist.

Quick checklist before you submit a photo

- ☐ Whole document in frame, all four edges visible
- ☐ In focus, no glare on the text
- ☐ Photographed with a phone, not scanned
- ☐ Unedited — no crop, filter, or auto-enhance
- ☐ Shop gave permission
- ☐ All six fields filled in on the shared sheet

Questions, or something in the shop does not match this guide? Ask in the team group before improvising — an inconsistently collected document usually cannot be fixed afterwards.